

POWER

ABCs of Politics – Session 6

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DISCOURSE *on* VOLUNTARY SERVITUDE

BILINGUAL EDITION

Notion of social contract □
legitimacy of power ; today's
question is quite different
(**mechanisms** of power)

Two types of question:

Conceptual question: what *is*
power?

Analytical question: how does
power work?

Distinction between power and
domination / authority (coercion vs
consent)

Structuralist vs relational approach

Descriptive vs critical approach

I. General definitions

II. Main approaches of power and
domination

I. Descriptive approach
(Weber)

II. Structuralist approach (Marx,
Bourdieu)

III. Relational approach
(Foucault)



INTRODUCTION

- Two types of question:
 - Conceptual question: what *is* power?
 - Analytical question: how does power work?
 - Distinction between power and domination / authority (coercion vs consent)
 - Structuralist vs relational approach
 - Descriptive vs critical approach
1. General definitions
 2. Main approaches of power and domination
 1. Descriptive approach (Weber)
 2. Structuralist approach (Marx, Bourdieu)
 3. Relational approach (Foucault)

WHAT IS POWER?

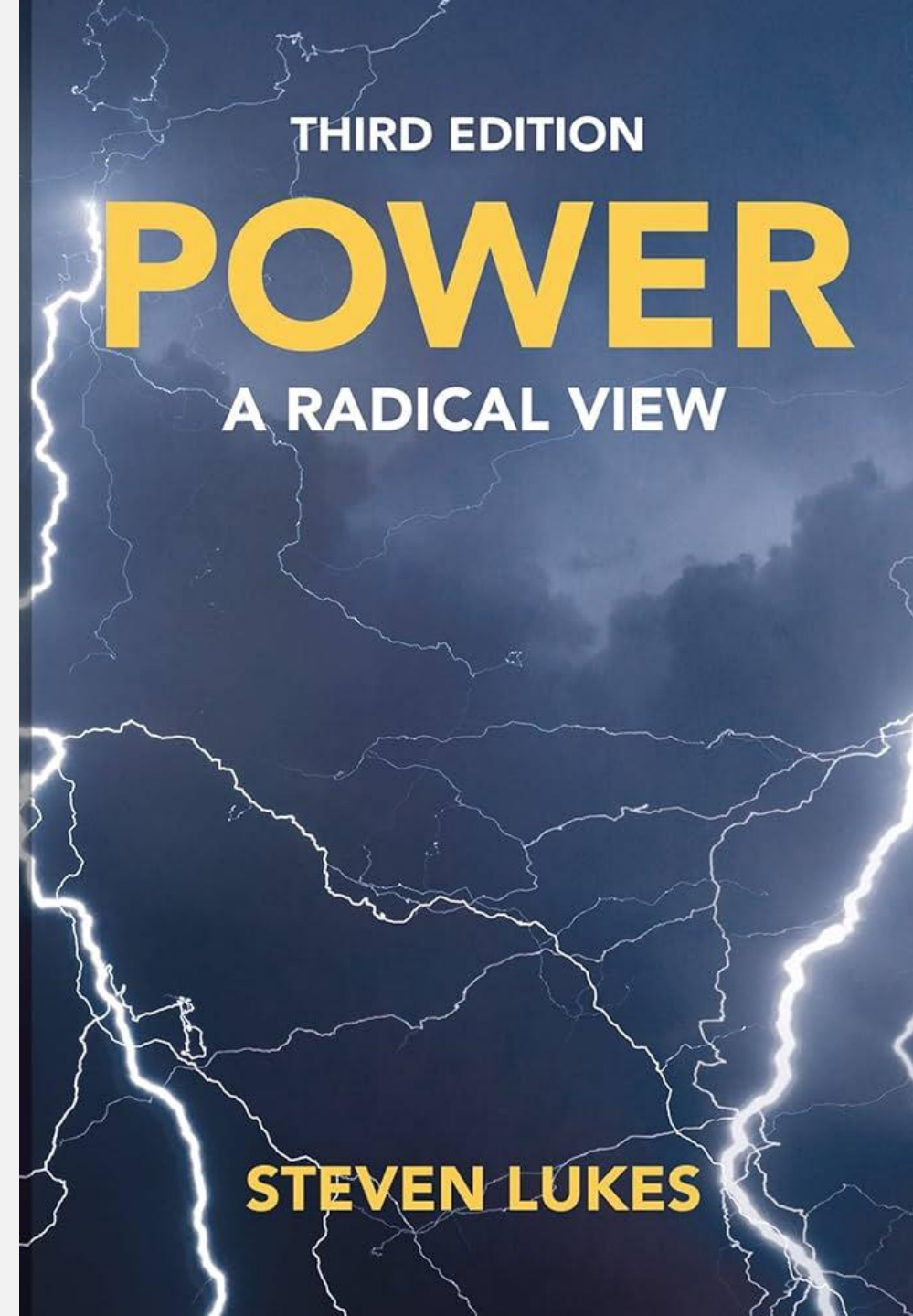
1. Power as an actuality or a potentiality
2. Power as individual or collective
3. Power as active or passive
4. Power as measure of scope vs outcomes of power
5. Power as a general capacity (*potential*) or as power over people (*potestas*)

Issue scope	Contextual range	Intentionality	Activity
Single-issue	Context-bound	Intended consequences	Active exercise
Multi-issue	Context-transcending	Unintended consequences	Inactive enjoyment

Figure 2.1

THE THREE-DIMENSIONAL CONCEPTION OF POWER (LUKES)

- One-dimensional: “A has the power over B to the extent that he can get B to do something that B would not otherwise do” (coercion)
- Two-dimensional: “Power is also exercised when A devotes his energies to creating or reinforcing social and political values and institutional practices that limit the scope of the political process to public consideration of only those issues which comparatively innocuous to A”
- Three-dimensional : “the capacity to shape interests against people’s objective interests”



FROM POWER TO DOMINATION

- Radical approach to power = beyond mere coercion (unwilling compliance)
- What's wrong with domination?
 - “Just” forms of domination? Paternalistic power, transformative power...
 - Underlying idea = domination is a form of power with a false/wrong compliance

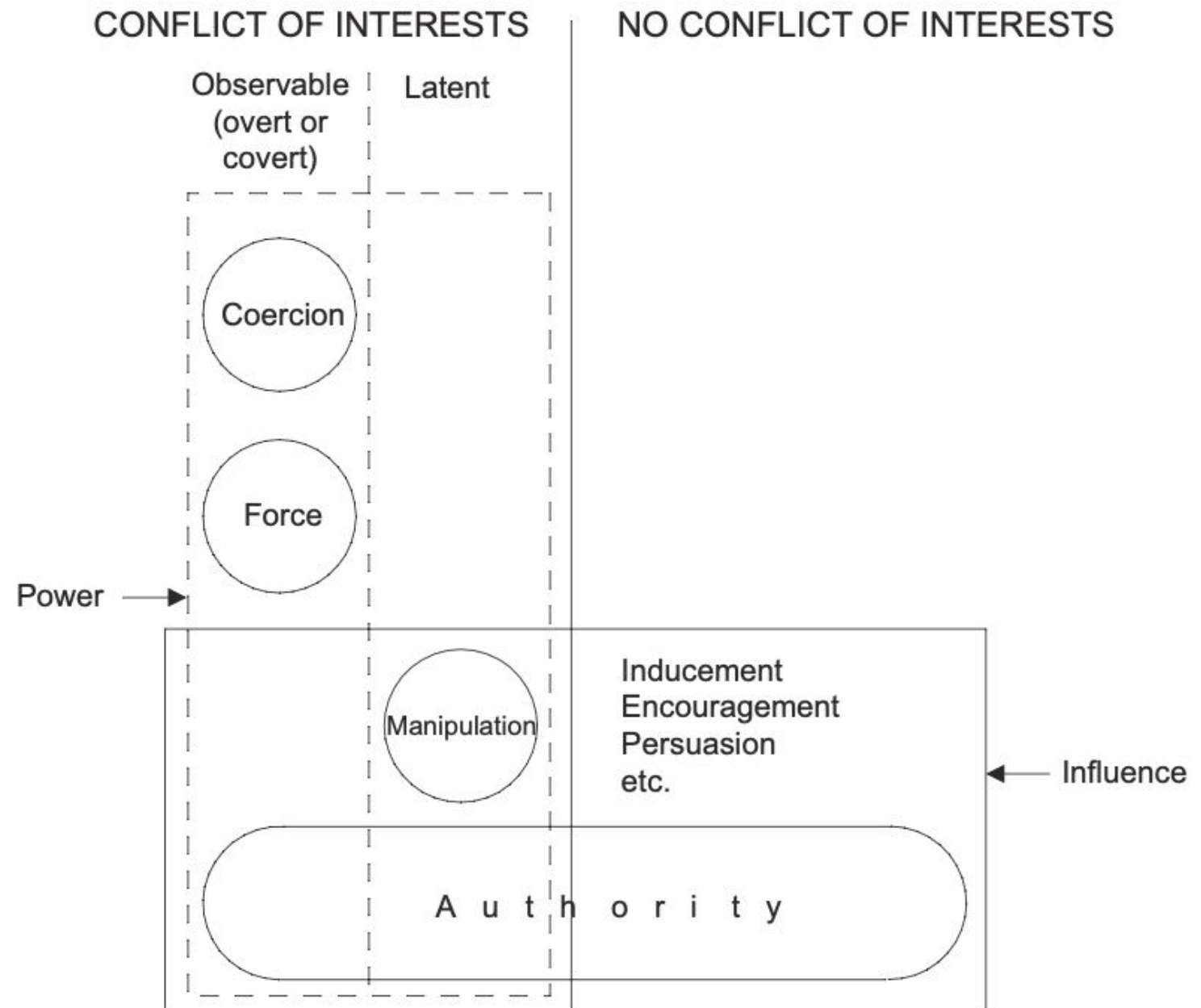
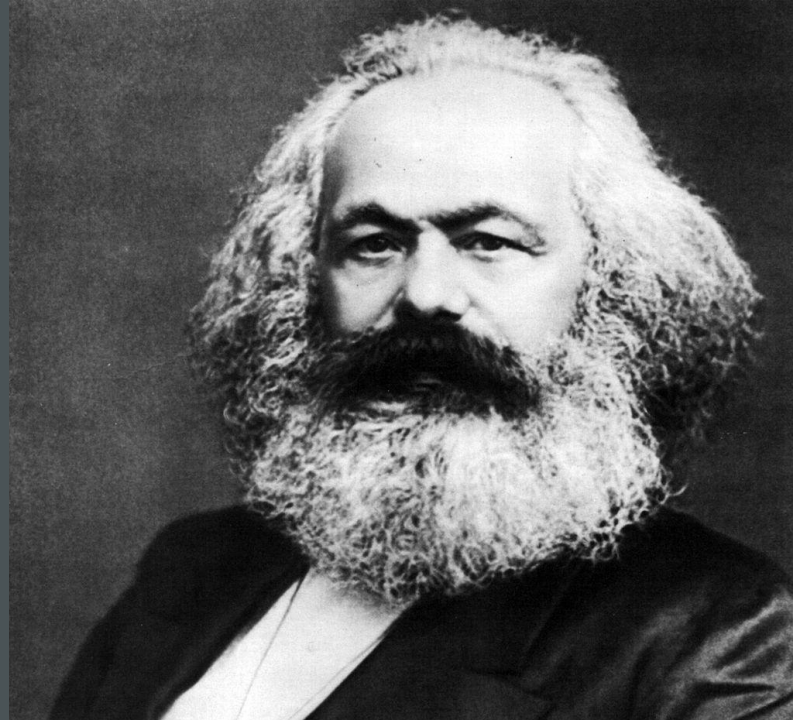


Figure 1.1

MAIN APPROACHES TO POWER AND DOMINATION

- Concept of domination = mainly normative, critical and political
- Domination = usually connected with a meta-theory □ discrepancy between objective and subjective interests
- Three main approaches:
 - Descriptive approach (Weber)
 - Structuralist approaches (Marx and Bourdieu)
 - Relational approach (Foucault)



WEBER ON AUTHORITY

Authority	Pure form	Dominant	Dominated	Rule	Justification
Rational-legal	Bureaucracy	Bureaucrat	Citizen	Formal	Skills
Traditional	Patriarchy	Master	Subject	Custom + Arbitrary	Tradition
Charismatic	Messiah	Chief	Disciple	Arbitrary	Affects

STRUCTURALIST APPROACH (MARX AND BOURDIEU)

- First assumption □ domination = stable (domination as product of a social *structure*)
- Second assumption □ critical approach to domination (needs to be *unveiled*)
- Example: the question of Taylorism
 - Weberian explanation: product of modern rationality
 - Marxian explanation: discipline of the workers (real subsumption of the labour-process); “efficiency” = expression of the interests of the ruling class

Mode of production	Base	Ideology
Slavery	Masters and slaves	Dualism btw natural free men and natural slaves
Feudal system	Lords and serfs (centrality of land)	Ownership of land depends on divine election
Capitalism	Owners of the means of production vs labour-power	Entrepreneurial myth □ success comes from its own abilities

MARXISM AND IDEOLOGY

Louis Althusser On Ideology

ALTHUSSER ON IDEOLOGY

- Wrong understanding of power (repressive rather than productive) ; power reduced to repressive State Apparatus
- First thesis: “ideology represents individual’s imaginary relations to their real conditions of existence”
- Second thesis: “Ideology has a material existence”
- Third thesis : “Ideology is based on interpellation”

BOURDIEU'S APPROACH

- Between Marx (ideology), Weber (legitimation process), Elias (cultural and symbolic dimensions)
- First assumption: domination is less political or economic than cultural (***symbolic violence***)
- Second assumption: domination is incorporated (***habitus***)

DISTINCTION

—
A SOCIAL CRITIQUE OF THE
JUDGEMENT OF TASTE



PIERRE BOURDIEU



THE RELATIONAL APPROACH TO POWER (FOUCAULT)

- The main targets of Foucault:
 - Marxist conception of power
 - First problem □ power is too “substantial” (power is the property of actors)
 - Second problem □ power is reduced to economic sphere
 - Sovereign approach to power □ common to Law and Political Theory ; power as a legal question
 - Outdated conception: relies on the problem of power as a problem of sovereignty
 - Modern societies = plurality of the sources of power

THE ELEMENTS OF POWER

- First element = *relational approach to power*
- Second element = *relationship between power and knowledge*
- Third element = *body as the object of power*
- Fourth element = *microphysics of power*

"Must be reckoned with by humanists, social scientists and political activists." —The New York Times Book Review

DISCIPLINE & PUNISH



THE BIRTH OF THE PRISON

MICHEL FOUCAULT

	Methodology	Source of power	Mechanisms of power	Permanence
Weber	Descriptive	Legitimacy	Dependent on the ideal-type (charisma, rationality, tradition)	Dependent on the ideal-type (tradition more stable than charisma)
Marx	Critical	Economic relations	Ideology	Structural approach
Bourdieu	Critical	Culture / Symbolic	Habitus (internalization)	Structural approach
Foucault	Critical	Power-knowledge	Microphysics	Relational approach

SUMMARY